COMPANY BRIEF · NOVEMBER 2026

Spotify

The world's largest audio subscription service, turning 20 and betting on AI and fandom. A full read on the company, its people, its brand, and how to talk to it.

Sample brief · focus: Senior Brand Designer

SUMMARY
The 60-second read

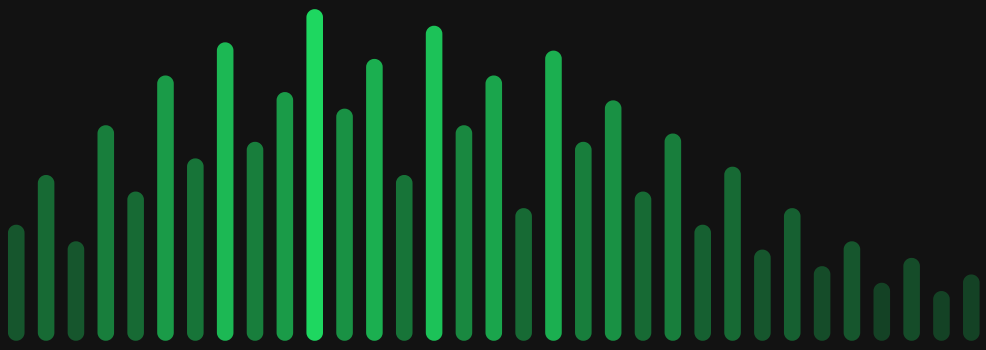
PART ONE
The company

PART TWO
People & culture

PART THREE
Brand & marketing

PART FOUR
Market & competition

PART FIVE
How to talk to them



Website spotify.com · **Offices** Stockholm, New York, London · **Founded** 2006 · **Ticker** NYSE: SPOT
Research date November 7, 2026 · SEC filings, Spotify's newsroom, developer guidelines, live site and careers page, and press

Independent research brief. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Spotify. Not legal or financial advice.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The 60-second read

Bottom line

Spotify is in the best financial shape of its 20 years: Q3 2026 revenue of €4.97B (+16%), a 13.5% operating margin, 788M users and 306M subscribers, with targets of 1B users and a 20%+ margin by 2030. Brand is product here (Wrapped, its own typeface, a 20th birthday that drove its biggest subscriber day ever), but hiring is lean: 77 open roles on Nov 7, one in design and none in brand.

2006 FOUNDED Stockholm · launched 2008	**~$124B** MARKET CAP Nov 6, 2026 · ~3% above end-2025	**€17.2B** 2025 REVENUE Q3 2026: €4.97B, +16%
7,000+ EMPLOYEES per 2025 annual report	**4.0 / 5** GLASSDOOR 77% recommend	**77** OPEN ROLES careers site, Nov 7, 2026

Three things to know before you walk in

- **New leaders, new era.** Co-CEOs Alex Norström and Gustav Söderström took over on Jan 1, 2026; founder Daniel Ek is executive chairman. Their pitch: move from recommending to generating, with Prompted Playlists, Taste Profile and a licensed remix tool with Universal Music.
- **Brand moments drive the business.** Wrapped 2025 reached 200M engaged users in about 24 hours; Spotify's 20th birthday experience drew ~100M people in six days and its biggest day of subscriber sign-ups ever.
- **Design roles are scarce right now.** Of 77 open jobs, 30 are engineering and one is design (a design systems role in London or Stockholm). The last US brand design posting closed in May 2026.

SIGNALS

Scorecard

Stability	●●●●●	Record 33% gross margin, €672M Q3 operating income, €3.2B free cash flow over 12 months.
Momentum	●●●●○	Users +11%, subscribers +9%, a clear 2030 plan; the stock is roughly flat over the past year.
Culture	●●●●○	Glassdoor 4.0, with work/life at 4.3; reviews flag middle management, reorgs and slow career growth.
Hiring and pay	●●○○○	Few design openings. The last NYC brand designer posting paid $96K–$137K base plus equity.
Brand ambition	●●●●●	Own typeface, Wrapped every December, Spotify Beach at Cannes, and public brand guidelines.

PART ONE

The company

01 At a glance

Name	Spotify Technology S.A. · spotify.com · NYSE: SPOT (direct listing Apr 3, 2018) REPORTED
Founded	2006 in Stockholm by Daniel Ek and Martin Lorentzon; the service launched in 2008 VERIFIED
Leadership	Co-CEOs Alex Norström and Gustav Söderström (since Jan 1, 2026); Daniel Ek, executive chairman; Christian Luiga, CFO VERIFIED
Offices	Registered in Luxembourg, run from Stockholm. Most open roles sit in London (40), Stockholm (31) and New York (20). VERIFIED
Employees	"More than 7,000," per the 2025 annual report VERIFIED
Audience	788M monthly users, including 306M subscribers, in 184 markets (Q3 2026) VERIFIED
Catalog	100M+ tracks, 8M podcast titles, 800,000 audiobooks in select markets VERIFIED
Mission	"To deliver creativity to the world—one note, one voice, one idea at a time." VERIFIED

02 What they do

Spotify streams music, podcasts and audiobooks on a free, ad-supported tier and a paid Premium tier. Free builds the habit and Premium earns the money; add-ons for the most engaged fans are the next layer. The homepage sums it up as "the ultimate home for music, artists, fans, live events, videos."

Products

PRODUCT	WHAT IT DOES	NOTE
Free	Ad-supported listening; the top of the funnel that converts to Premium over time	Ad revenue €482M, Q3
Premium	No ads, offline, lossless audio (announced Sep 2025); US individual plan $12.99 since Feb 2026	€4.49B, Q3
Audiobooks+	Paid add-on with more listening hours; expanding from 22 to 180+ markets by end of 2026	1M+ paying users
Video podcasts	Video shows in the app; Spotify Studios and The Ringer shows also stream on Netflix from 2026	Partner Program, 35+ new markets
Personal AI	Prompted Playlists (Jan 2026), Taste Profile you can edit (Mar 2026), Jam, Listening Activity	Jam: ~50M users

PRODUCT	WHAT IT DOES	NOTE
Spotify Advertising	Audio, video and display ads, plus Sponsored Playlists and Carousel Ads (Mar 2026)	Spotify Beach at Cannes
Spotify for Artists	Tools and payouts for artists, creators and authors; $11B+ paid to the music industry in 2025	$70B+ all time

How they make money

About 90% of revenue is Premium subscriptions (€4.49B of €4.97B in Q3 2026); the rest is advertising, which grew 10%. Margins come from price rises, add-ons like Audiobooks+, and keeping royalty growth below revenue growth. VERIFIED

Known for

Wrapped, the year-end listening recap that becomes a global social moment every December; the bright green brand; personalization; and paying out more to the music industry than any other service.

03 Mission, vision & goals

> "This was a quarter where we did what we said."
>
> Alex Norström, co-CEO, Q3 2026 results · Oct 22, 2026

At the May 2026 Investor Day, the co-CEOs laid out four ideas for the next chapter VERIFIED:

- **The power law.** There is no average user, so Spotify sells more to its biggest fans: add-ons such as Audiobooks+ and a coming paid remix tool.
- **Multiplayer.** From solo listening to shared: Jam and collaborative playlists each reach about 50M people.
- **Generation.** From recommending to creating, powered by what Spotify calls a "Large Taste Model." Söderström says Spotify "actually stands to thrive in the agentic age."
- **Time Well Spent.** No engagement at any cost: people pay for time they don't regret. Presented by Nicole Burrow, VP of Product Design.

2030 targets: 1 billion active users, an operating margin above 20%, a 35–40% gross margin and mid-teens growth REPORTED. Longer term, the company talks about one day reaching a billion subscribers.

04 History

2006
Founded in Stockholm by Daniel Ek and Martin Lorentzon. The name came from a misheard word in a brainstorm.

2008
The service launches in Sweden.

2011
Launches in the United States.

Apr 3, 2018
Direct listing on the New York Stock Exchange, closing its first day at a $26.5B market cap.

2019–2022
Podcasts (Gimlet, Anchor), then audiobooks.

2023–24
About 1,500 jobs cut, around 17% of the workforce.

May 2024
Spotify Mix, a custom typeface by Dinamo, replaces Circular.

Sep 2025
Lossless audio (Sep 10); Ek to step back as CEO (Sep 30).

Oct–Dec 2025
Netflix video podcast deal; Wrapped 2025 sets records.

Jan 2026
Co-CEOs take over; US Premium rises to $12.99; Prompted Playlists launch.

May 2026
20th birthday campaign (May 12) and Investor Day with 2030 targets (May 21).

Oct 22, 2026
Q3 results: 788M users, 306M subscribers, record margins.

05 Financials

€4.97B	33.0%	13.5%	€3.2B
Q3 2026 REVENUE	Q3 GROSS MARGIN	Q3 OP. MARGIN	12-MONTH FREE CASH FLOW

PERIOD	REVENUE	GROWTH	OP. INCOME	NOTE
FY2025	€17.19B	—	~€2.2B	32% gross margin; operating income calculated from the filing ESTIMATE
Q3 2026	€4.97B	+16%	€672M	+14% at constant currency; Premium +17%, ads +10% VERIFIED
Q4 2026 (guide)	€5.2B	—	€820M	818M users, 316M subscribers, 33.8% gross margin VERIFIED

The stock closed near $603 on Nov 6, 2026, a ~$124B market cap: about 3% above the end of 2025 and roughly flat over 12 months, even as profits hit records. Investors are weighing AI risk against the 2030 plan. REPORTED

PART TWO

People & culture

06 People to know

Alex Norström
Co-CEO
Runs the business side: subscriptions, markets, ads. Opened Investor Day on Spotify as a home for creativity and culture.

Gustav Söderström
Co-CEO
Product and technology. The voice of the AI "generation" strategy.

Daniel Ek
Founder, executive chairman
CEO until the end of 2025; now focused on long-term strategy and capital.

Nicole Burrow
VP of Product Design
Presented "Time Well Spent" at Investor Day: design choices that make time on Spotify feel worth it.

Bridget Evans
Global Head of Business Marketing
Led the Cannes 2026 message to brands: fandom is the most valuable audience.

Christian Luiga
CFO (since 2024)
Owns the 2030 margin targets and the "reinvest versus profit" balance.

Charlie Hellman
SVP, Global Head of Music
Announced the Universal Music deal for licensed fan remixes.

Gustav Gyllenhammar
SVP, Markets & Subscriptions
Runs the free-to-Premium playbook and local campaigns.

07 Hiring

77
OPEN ROLES
lifeatspotify.com, Nov 7, 2026

1
DESIGN ROLES
Staff Product Designer, design systems

6
MARKETING ROLES
consumer and content marketing

DEPARTMENT	ROLES	DEPARTMENT	ROLES
Engineering	30	Marketing	6
Product	12	Support & Operations	4
Sales	10	Content, HR	2 each
Data, Research & Insights	9	Design, Legal	1 each

The closest recent brand role

ROLE	LOCATION	PAY	NOTES
Designer, Brand and Marketing (Spotify Advertising)	New York hybrid; open US-wide on Eastern time	$96K–$137K + equity	Sales collateral, decks, digital ads, landing pages; Adobe CC and Figma, After Effects a plus; 4+ years. Removed May 13, 2026. REPORTED

Benefits listed on that posting: six months of paid parental leave, a 401(k), a monthly meal allowance, 23 paid days off and 13 flexible holidays. Indeed reviewers rate interviews medium difficulty and about two weeks long. With engineering and AI taking most openings, brand roles are worth watching for rather than waiting on; set a job alert under Design and Marketing.

08 What employees say

4.0	77%	4.3	75%
GLASSDOOR	RECOMMEND	WORK/LIFE	INDEED RECOMMEND
1,400+ reviews	Glassdoor	highest category	27 of 36

Praised

- Culture and values (4.2)
- Remote-friendly ways of working
- Benefits, especially parental leave and equity
- Colleagues you learn from

Criticized

- Inexperienced middle management
- Career growth (3.6, the lowest score)
- Frequent reorganizations and layoffs
- Pay that lags in some locations

Glassdoor's full page was behind a bot check, so this uses its public summary (accessed Nov 7, 2026) plus Indeed. Blind and Comparably weren't checked.

09 Culture & values

Time Well Spent	A business strategy as much as a value: design for time people don't regret, because people pay for that. Spotify cites a study ranking it No. 1 among major platforms on this. COMPANY CLAIM
Product meets culture	Marketing runs through the product: Wrapped, Spotify 20, artist moments. Brand designers work close to product and data.
AI with consent	Generative features are framed around artist "consent, credit, and compensation" (the Universal Music deal).
Swedish roots	Collaborative and consensus-minded; reviewers describe a strong culture but slower career paths.
Lean and focused	About 1,500 jobs cut in 2023–24 and about 15 more in podcasts in Mar 2026; hiring is targeted.

PART THREE

Brand & marketing

10 Brand identity

Logo

A circle holding three curved bars that read as sound waves, shown green on black or white; the full logo pairs it with a bold, rounded wordmark. The icon can stand alone; the wordmark never appears without it. For the 20th birthday the app icon briefly became a green disco ball. This brief describes the logo rather than reproducing it.

Art direction

Black and near-black surfaces with Spotify Green as the signal color, pill-shaped buttons, and artist imagery up front. Campaigns lean bright, personal and data-driven: Wrapped turns listening stats into shareable stories in a new art direction each year.

Color, from the live site's CSS (spotify.com, Nov 7, 2026) VERIFIED

Spotify Green	Near Black	Graphite	Silver	White
#1ED760 · signal, buttons	#121212 · app surfaces	#242424 · cards	#B3B3B3 · secondary text	#FFFFFF · text on dark

Type

The ultimate home for music

Spotify Mix, a custom typeface by Dinamo (2024) with sharp angles and smooth curves, replaced Circular. The site runs SpotifyMixUI for text and SpotifyMixUITitle for headings at weight 900. It's proprietary, so this brief uses Figtree as a free stand-in.

Voice

Sounds like

- Warm and a little cheeky: "It's our 20th birthday, but the gifts are for you."
- Personal: your year, your taste, your party of the years.
- Fan-first: artists and listeners, not features.

Never sounds like

- Engagement-bait or dark patterns (Time Well Spent)
- Tech jargon in consumer copy
- Corporate distance

11 Brand kit & who makes it

Links only. Use is governed by Spotify's Design & Branding Guidelines. Each ZIP was opened and its file list read on Nov 7, 2026.

ASSET	FORMAT	SOURCE	DATE	STATUS
Full logo (icon + wordmark)	ZIP: SVG, EPS, AI, PDF, PNG · green, black, white · RGB, CMYK, Pantone	Spotify for Developers OFFICIAL	2024 files	Current
Icon	ZIP: SVG, EPS, AI, PDF, PNG · same sets	Spotify for Developers OFFICIAL	2024 files	Current
Design & Branding Guidelines	Web page	Spotify for Developers OFFICIAL	No date; © 2026	Current, for partners
Press logo pack	PNG (raster) ×6 + "download all" ZIP	Spotify Press Center OFFICIAL	2024 files	Current
Media kits	Images, video: 2025 Wrapped (149 files), Investor Day 2026 (116)…	Spotify Press Center OFFICIAL	2025–26	Current
Fonts	Spotify Mix (Dinamo)	Proprietary; not publicly licensed	May 2024	Request access
Color specs	HEX from site CSS; logo files include CMYK and Pantone versions	spotify.com OFFICIAL	Nov 2026	No public palette sheet

Rules a designer needs (from the guidelines)

- Green logo only on black, white, or non-duotoned photos; black on light backgrounds, white on dark.
- Clear space equal to half the icon's height. Minimum size: full logo 70px or 20mm, icon 21px or 6mm.
- Don't rotate, stretch, recolor or redraw the logo, use it in a sentence, or co-brand it.
- Show album art as supplied, with 4px corners on small and medium screens and 8px on large.

In-house team	Product design under Nicole Burrow (VP of Product Design); brand and marketing design teams in marketing and in Spotify Advertising; spotify.design publishes the team's work.
Partners	Dinamo made Spotify Mix. Agencies for Wrapped and Spotify 20 weren't named in the coverage reviewed.

12 Advertising & campaigns

May 2026

Spotify 20: "Your Party of the Year(s)"

In-app, app icon, spotify.com/20, social

An all-time recap: your first day, top artists and songs ever, plus a temporary disco-ball app icon. About 100M people engaged in six days, driving Spotify's biggest day of subscriber sign-ups ever.

Dec 2025

Wrapped 2025

In-app stories, social, out of home

200M engaged users in about 24 hours (+19%) and ~500M shares (+41%). New this year: multiplayer, Listening Age and Clubs. Spotify counts 620M+ Wrapped shares over 2025.

Mar 2026

New ad formats
Spotify Advertising
Sponsored Playlists and Carousel Ads, giving brands placements inside listening rather than around it.

13 Activations, events & sponsorships

Jun 22–26, 2026

Spotify Beach, Cannes Lions
Cannes · for advertisers and agencies
Sets from RAYE, Central Cee, Lykke Li, Mumford & Sons and John Summit; talks with Troye Sivan and Anderson .Paak. Message: fandom is the most valuable audience a brand can reach.

May 21, 2026

Investor Day
Highline Stages, New York
Staged as a physical version of the app, including a set built like a podcast studio. A brand experience aimed at investors.

14 Social, video & reading

Spotify posts as @spotify on Instagram, TikTok and X, and as Spotify on YouTube. Its newsroom, "For the Record," carries every launch, and spotify.design publishes the design team's work. Follower counts weren't retrievable in this session.

Read before you talk to them

May 2026

Investor Day 2026 recap
Spotify newsroom · 10-minute read
The strategy in Spotify's own words, including the product design lead's view of "Time Well Spent."

Oct 2026

Q3 2026 earnings
Spotify newsroom
Latest numbers and product priorities.

May 2024

Spotify launches its own font
TechCrunch
Why Spotify built Spotify Mix, and what changed in the app.

Ongoing

A design system isn't one size fits all
spotify.design · 2018, dated
How Spotify's designers think about shared foundations versus team freedom.

15 In the news (last 12 months)

Oct 22, 2026

Q3: 306M subscribers, record margins
Spotify newsroom
Audiobooks to 180+ markets; Fresh Finds Forward for 10,000 emerging artists a year.

Sep 17, 2026	**Partner Program expands to 35+ markets** Spotify newsroom	More creators paid for video podcasts.
May 21, 2026	**Investor Day sets 2030 targets** Fortune	1B users, 20%+ margin; licensed AI remix tool with Universal Music.
Mar 23, 2026	**About 15 podcast jobs cut** Digital Music News	~3% of the podcast group at The Ringer and Spotify Studios.
Jan 15, 2026	**US Premium rises to $12.99** iClarified	From $11.99, for billing from February.
Oct 16, 2025	**Spotify video podcasts head to Netflix** Radio Ink	Ringer and Spotify Studios shows on Netflix from early 2026.

PART FOUR

Market & competition

16 The market

Paid music streaming reached 921.6M subscribers worldwide in 2025 (+10.1%), and the industry is closing in on a billion. Over 70% of new subscribers now come from Latin America, Asia-Pacific and other emerging regions. Spotify leads in the Americas and Europe; YouTube Music is the fastest-growing service and has passed Spotify in the Middle East and North Africa. The next fight is over AI-made music, add-on spending by superfans, and video.

REPORTED

17 Competitors

COMPANY	POSITIONING	SCALE	VS. SPOTIFY
Spotify	Freemium audio: music, podcasts, audiobooks	788M users · 306M subs	—
YouTube Music (Alphabet)	Bundled with YouTube Premium; video-first	150M+ subs incl. trials	Fastest-growing; owns music video and creators
Apple Music	Bundled with Apple One and devices	Not disclosed	$2 cheaper in the US ($10.99 vs $12.99); Apple also runs the App Store
Amazon Music	Included with Prime, plus Unlimited tier	Not disclosed	Reach through Prime and Alexa

18 Customers & partners

Listeners are the customers: 788M a month, 306M of them paying. Advertisers buy through Spotify Advertising. Universal, Sony, Warner and Merlin account for about 72% of label streams. Partners include Universal Music (licensed AI remixes), Netflix (video podcasts), Peloton (Fitness with Spotify) and creators in the Partner Program.

VERIFIED REPORTED

19 Risks & red flags

Watch for

- **AI disruption.** Generated music and AI assistants could shift where listening happens. Spotify's answer is licensed, consent-based AI, still unproven as a product.
- **Label dependence.** Four rights holders control about 72% of label streams, and €2.7B of content commitments are fixed.
- **Platform gatekeepers.** Apple, Google and Amazon run the app stores and devices Spotify relies on, and compete with it.
- **Few design openings, frequent reorgs.** Brand roles open rarely, and reviews cite regular reorganizations.

PART FIVE

How to talk to them

20 Their language

Time Well Spent	The design principle: build experiences people don't regret.
Wrapped	The year-end personal recap each December. The brand's biggest moment.
Freemium	Free tier first, Premium later. The core growth model.
MAU	Monthly active users (788M). Subscribers are counted separately.
Superfans, power law	The most engaged users, who will pay for add-ons.
Multiplayer	Shared listening: Jam, collaborative playlists, Listening Activity.
Taste Profile	Your listening profile, now visible and editable.
Prompted Playlists	Playlists made from a text prompt.
Large Taste Model	Spotify's name for the AI behind its personalization.
Creators	Artists, podcasters and authors, all treated as partners.
For the Record	The newsroom.
Spotify Mix	The house typeface. Know it if you're a brand designer.

21 What they care about → how to talk about it

THEY CARE ABOUT	EVIDENCE	SAY SOMETHING LIKE
Moments people share	Wrapped, 620M+ shares; Spotify 20	"Show the work where data became a story people wanted to post."
Time Well Spent	Investor Day pillar from the VP of Product Design	"Explain how your design earned attention rather than grabbed it."
Fans and artists	Cannes message; $11B+ paid to music in 2025	"Talk about designing with an artist, not just for a client."
Personal AI, with consent	Prompted Playlists, Taste Profile, Universal deal	"Say where AI belongs in your process, and where it doesn't."
Brand consistency at scale	Spotify Mix, 184 markets, strict logo rules	"Bring a system you built that other people used well."

22 Angles that land

Lead with

- **Data turned into culture.** Any work that made numbers personal and shareable maps straight to Wrapped.
- **Systems plus expression.** A brand system and a campaign that bent it on purpose.
- **Motion and social.** Spotify's brand lives in stories, short video and in-app moments.
- **Global range.** Work adapted for many markets or languages.

Be ready for

- A portfolio walkthrough focused on process, not just finals.
- Questions about working with product, data and engineering.
- A view on Wrapped: what you'd keep and what you'd change.
- How you use AI tools, and how you protect artists' work.

23 Interview prep (Senior Brand Designer)

- **Likely process.** Recruiter screen, hiring manager conversation, portfolio presentation to the team, then a few one-on-ones with design and marketing partners. Indeed reviewers put the whole process at about two weeks. Inferred from reviews; confirm with the recruiter.
- **Likely questions** (inferred from the brand role posting and Investor Day themes):
  - Tell us about a campaign where data or personalization was the creative idea.
  - How do you keep a brand consistent across 184 markets without making it bland?
  - Walk us through a system you designed and how other teams used it.
  - How would you design for "Time Well Spent"?
  - Where do AI tools speed up your work, and where don't you use them?
  - How do you work with product managers and engineers on in-app brand moments?
- **How to frame answers.** Start with the listener or fan, then the idea, the craft and the result. Spotify likes numbers, so bring them.

24 Questions to ask

01 Where does brand design sit: marketing, product, or Spotify Advertising?
Spotify has brand designers in several places, with different work and partners.

02 How involved is brand design in Wrapped and in-app moments?
The brand's biggest moments live in the product.

03 How will Spotify Mix and the identity evolve as AI features grow?
Shows you know the system and the strategy.

04 How does the team measure whether a campaign was "time well spent"?
Ties your craft to the Investor Day pillar.

05 What does great look like in the first six months?
Clarifies expectations in a lean hiring year.

25 Do's & don'ts

Do

- Use the app before the call: Wrapped history, Jam, Prompted Playlists.
- Say "listeners," "fans" and "creators."
- Show process, iterations and results.
- Know Spotify Mix and the logo rules.

Don't

- Mock up work using the Spotify logo in ways the guidelines forbid.
- Pitch engagement tricks; they run against Time Well Spent.
- Show AI art that imitates real artists.
- Treat podcasts or audiobooks as afterthoughts.

26 Outreach

To a Spotify recruiter or design leader, on LinkedIn

Hi [name], I'm a senior brand designer who loves work where data becomes something people want to share, which is why Wrapped stands out to me. I'd love to be on your radar for brand design roles. Portfolio: [link]. Thanks, [name]

With only one design role open, a short note plus a job alert is better than a cold application to an unrelated posting.

27 Sources

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